

Predicting grammatical possibility

The dative alternation after probabilistic grammar, open data, and neural language models

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Abstract

TODO: Draft after the data situation is verified. The likely contribution is a no-new-data reassessment of Bresnan et al. (2007): reproduce the classic dative-alternation result, update the modelling and validation strategy, test cross-corpus generalization, and use the case to clarify the difference between rare, dispreferred, probabilistically conditioned, and ungrammatical forms.

Keywords: dative alternation; probabilistic grammar; grammaticality; corpus linguistics; acceptability

1 THE PROBLEM

TODO: Open from the distinction the project needs: a construction can be rare, lexically restricted, strongly dispreferred, register-bound, or contrary to a linguist’s informal judgment without thereby falling outside the grammar. The dative alternation is useful because the choice between the double-object and prepositional patterns has both a long theoretical history and a reusable probabilistic dataset.

2 THE ORIGINAL TARGET

TODO: Present Bresnan et al. (2007) as the conceptual and empirical anchor: probabilistic corpus modelling as evidence about grammatical possibility, not as a replacement for grammar. Keep the level distinction explicit: corpus-distributional evidence is being used to test claims about a production-choice profile, not to reduce grammar to frequency.

3 DATA AND DIRECT REPLICATION

TODO: Verify and document the ‘languageR’ dative dataset before analysis. The first empirical pass should reproduce the original data structure and modelling target as closely as possible, then identify where a faithful replication ends and a modern update begins.

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4 MODERN MODELLING UPDATE

TODO: Decide whether the main update is mixed-effects logistic regression, Bayesian hierarchical modelling, regularized prediction, cross-validation, or a sequence of increasingly explicit models. The analysis should not become a statistics showcase; each modelling choice must answer a grammatical question.

5 GENERALIZATION AND ACCEPTABILITY

TODO: After verifying the later datasets, ask whether the same conditioning profile generalizes across corpus design, modality, period, and variety. If acceptability resources enter the paper, mark the level shift: production probability and acceptability preference are related evidence streams, not the same measurement.

6 GRAMMATICAL POSSIBILITY

TODO: Connect the empirical result back to the broader *(Un)grammatical* program. The payoff should be a sharper vocabulary for saying that an alternation is grammatical but conditioned, possible but dispreferred, or outside the projection profile supported by the evidence.

7 CONCLUSION

TODO: Conclude with the methodological lesson, not the dataset. The project should show how a classic corpus-probabilistic result can be made reproducible, portable, and conceptually useful for the ontology of grammatical possibility.

DATA AND CODE AVAILABILITY

No data has been downloaded or analysed in this setup draft. The intended project uses reusable public datasets where licensing and documentation permit it; source and dataset verification are tracked in `notes/source-verification.md`.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

TODO: Add final AI-use disclosure with the actual model list used on the project.

REFERENCES

- Bresnan, J., Cueni, A., Nikitina, T., & Baayen, R. H. (2007). Predicting the dative alternation. In G. Bouma, I. Krämer & J. Zwarts (Eds.), *Cognitive foundations of interpretation* (pp. 69–94). Royal Netherlands Academy of Arts; Sciences.